And Weep, Like Alexander

By Neil Gaiman

INTRODUCTION

Alexander Graham Bell, best known for his invention of the telephone, revolutionized communication as we know it. Let's face it, he laid the building blocks of smart phone technology. Texting, e-mails, selfies, social media, emojis, games and even television stream to us 24-7 through the current version of the first telephone invented in the 1800s. What would we do without it?

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NARRATOR: **(Pg 303+)** The little man hurried into the Fountain and ordered a very large whisky.

OBEDIAH: Because . . . I deserve it.

BRIAN: I'm sure you do.

NARRATOR: He looked exhausted, sweaty and rumpled, as if he had not slept in several days. He wore a tie, but it was so loose as to be almost undone. He had greying hair that might once have been ginger. He took a sip of the whisky as if to find out whether or not he liked it, then, satisfied, gulped down half the glass. He stood completely still, for a moment, like a statue.

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OBEDIAH: Listen. Can you hear it? - A sort of background whispering white noise that actually becomes whatever song you wish to hear when you sort of half-concentrate upon it?

NARRATOR: *(listening)* No.

OBEDIAH: Exactly! *(pleased with himself)* Isn't it ***wonderful***? Only yesterday, everybody in the Fountain was complaining about the Wispamuzak. Professor Mackintosh here was grumbling about having Queen's "Bohemian Rhapsody" stuck in his head and how it was now following him across London. Today, it's gone, as if it had never been. None of you can even remember that it existed. And that is all due to me.

PROF MACKINTOSH: I what? . . . Something about the Queen? . . . Do I know you?

OBEDIAH: We met. But people forget me, alas. It is because of my job.

NARRATOR: He took out his wallet, produced a card, passed it to me: *(reads the card aloud)* **OBEDIAH**

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POLKINGHORN – UNINVENTOR *(to Obediah)* If you don't mind my asking, What's an uninventor?

OBEDIAH: It's somebody who uninvents things. *(raises his empty glass)* Ah. Excuse me. Sally, I need another very large whiskey.

NARRATOR: The rest of the crowd there that evening seemed to have decided that the man was both mad and uninteresting. They had returned to their conversations. I, on the other hand, was caught. *(to Obediah)* So, have you been an uninventor long?'

OBEDIAH: Since I was fairly young. I started uninventing when I was eighteen. Have you never wondered why we do not have jet-packs?

NARRATOR: I had, actually.

MICHAEL: Saw a bit on *Tomorrow's World* about them, when I was a lad. Man went up in one. Then he came down. Raymond Burr seemed to think we'd all have them soon enough.

OBEDIAH: Ah, but we don't, because I uninvented them about twenty years ago. I had to. They were driving everybody mad. I mean, they seemed so attractive, and so cheap, but you just had to have a few

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thousand bored teenagers strapping them on, zooming all over the place, hovering outside bedroom windows, crashing into the flying cars . . .

SALLY: Hold on. There aren't any flying cars.

OBEDIAH: True, but only because I uninvented them. You wouldn't believe the traffic jams they cause. I'd look up and it was just the bottoms of bloody flying cars from horizon to horizon. Some days I couldn't see the skies at all. People throwing rubbish out of their car windows . . . They were easy to run – ran off gravitosolar power, obviously – but I didn't realize that they needed to go until I heard a lady talking about them on Radio Four, all "Why Oh Why Didn't We Stick with Non-Flying Cars?" She had a point. Something needed to be done. I uninvented them. I made a list of inventions the world would be better off without and, one by one, I uninvented them all.

NARRATOR: By now he had started to gather a small audience. I was pleased I had a good seat.

OBEDIAH: It was a lot of work, too. You see, it's almost impossible *not* to invent the flying car, as soon as you've invented the Lumenbubble. So eventually I had

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to uninvent them too. And I miss the individual Lumenbubble: a massless portable light source that floated half a metre above your head and went on when you wanted it to. Such a wonderful invention. Still, no use crying over unspilt milk, and you can't mend an omelette without unbreaking a few eggs.

JOCELYN: You also can't expect us actually to believe any of this!

BRIAN: Right. I mean, next thing you'll be telling us that you uninvented the spaceship.

OBEDIAH: But I did. *(very pleased with himself)* Twice. I had to. You see, the moment we whizz off into space and head out to the planets and beyond, we bump into things that spur so many other inventions. The Polaroid Instant Transporter. That was the worst. And the Mockett Telepathic Translator. That was the worst as well. But as long as it's nothing worse than a rocket to the moon, I can keep everything under control.

NARRATOR: So, how exactly do you go about uninventing things?

OBEDIAH: It's hard. It's all about unpicking probability threads from the fabric of creation. Which is a bit like

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unpicking a needle from a haystack. But they tend to be long and tangled, like spaghetti. So it's rather like having to unpick a strand of spaghetti from a haystack. . . I pride myself on doing good. Each day I wake, and, even if I've unhappened something that might have been wonderful, I think, Obediah Polkinghorn, the world is a happier place because of something that you've uninvented. *(he pauses to gaze into his glass)* The trouble is with the Wispamuzak gone, that's it. I'm done. It's all been uninvented. There are no more horizons left to undiscover, no more mountains left to unclimb.

TWEET: Nuclear power?

OBEDIAH: Before my time. Can't uninvent things invented before I was born. Otherwise I might uninvent something that would have led to my birth, and then where would we be? (silence) Kneehigh in jet-packs and flying cars, that's where. Not to mention Morrison's Martian Emolument. *(looking quite grim)* Ooh. That stuff was nasty. And a cure for cancer. But frankly, given what it did to the oceans, I'd rather have the cancer. *(pause)* No. I have uninvented

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everything that was on my list. *(bravely)* I shall go home, and weep, like Alexander, because there are no more worlds to unconquer. What is there left to uninvent?

NARRATOR: There was silence in the Fountain. In the silence, Brian's iPhone rang. His ringtone was the Rutles singing 'Cheese and Onions'.

BRIAN: Yeah? I'll call you back.

NARRATOR: It is unfortunate that the pulling out of one phone can have such an effect on other people around. Sometimes I think it's because we remember when we could smoke in pubs, and that we pull out our phones together as once we pulled out our cigarette packets. But probably it's because we're easily bored. Whatever the reason, the phones came out. Crown Baker took a photo of us all, and then Twitpicced it. Jocelyn started to read her text messages. 'Tweet' Peston tweeted that he was in the Fountain and had met his first uninventor. Professor Mackintosh checked the test match scores, told us what they were and emailed his brother in Inverness

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to grumble about them. The phones were out and the conversation was over.

OBEDIAH: What's that?

RAY: *(holding his phone up)* It's the iPhone 5. Crown's using the Nexus X. That's the Android system. Phones. Internet. Camera. Music. But it's the apps. I mean, do you know, there are over a thousand fart sound effect apps on the iPhone alone? You want to hear the unofficial Simpsons Fart App?'

OBEDIAH: No. *(offended)* I most definitely do not want to. I do *not*.

NARRATOR: He put down his drink, unfinished. Pulled his tie up. Did up his coat.

OBEDIAH: *(speaking to himself)* It's not going to be easy But, for the good of all . . . *(he smiles) (to the bar)* It's been marvelous talking to you all! (he whistles as he exits)

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AWARD HISTORY

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